Three Days to the Trial

The trial is announced, and Yara has three days to get ready

Yara is seventeen, half human and half Vey'kar, and she leads the east trail now, by the village's word. Tonight, at the fire, her mother will announce her trial — and keep a promise made on the night of the east trail: one true thing about her father.

Daughter of Two Worlds was written by BiomassFlood, with AI assistance from Luna for drafting and editing. All characters, worldbuilding, and story decisions are the author's own original work.

CHAPTER 7

THE MORNING OF THE FIRE

The day the trial was to be announced began the way the last three days had begun: with Yara waking before the sun, and lying still in her shelter, and listening to the village wake up around her, and thinking about the promise her mother had made her.

Three days. That was what Oya had said at the fire, three nights ago, when Jabari had called for the trial and the whole village had heard it. In three days, at the fire, I will announce Yara's trial. And now the three days were done, and tonight was the night, and Yara lay in the dark and felt the words land in her chest all over again, heavy and bright at once.

And under the trial, underneath it like a root under a tree, was the other promise, the older one, the one her mother had made her on the night she led the east trail: one true thing about her father, when the east trail was hers by daylight too.

It was hers now. It was hers by dark, and it was hers by the village's word, and it was hers by Jabari's word, which was the hardest word of all to earn, and it was hers by daylight too, because she had walked it in the sun with Amara, and she had brought home a name, and a promise, and a friend, and the village had not fallen down around her for it.

So tonight, she thought, and her markings flared, bright and blue, in the dark of her shelter, before she could stop them, and she breathed them down again, slow and steady, the way Amara had taught her. Tonight, at the fire, her mother would announce the trial, and then, if the promise was still a promise, her mother would tell her one true thing about her father.

She got up, and she dressed, and she put the bone charm at her belt, and she felt it hum, once, low and warm, against her hip, the way it had hummed on the night of the second chapter, and on the night of the fifth, and on the night of the sixth.

Outside, the village was already moving. The new family, the one that had come in on the river trail at dawn three days ago, was settling in at the edge of the trees, and their small boy, no older than six, was chasing the same chicken that did not belong to anyone, and laughing like the world had never had a snare in it, and the old woman was sitting in the sun, watching him, and smiling.

"Yara," Zola said, appearing at her elbow the way she always did, sudden and warm and a little bit out of breath, and her grin was wide, though Yara could see the worry underneath it, the way she always could with Zola. "Tonight is the night. The fire, the announcement, the whole village, all of it. Are you ready?"

Yara nodded, and she felt the pride in her chest stand up a little straighter, and then the fear that came with it.

"I am as ready as I can be," she said, and her voice was steady, and it was her voice, and it was also, she realised, her mother's voice, the way Oya's voice sounded when she gave an order she wished she did not have to give. "And if I am not ready, then I will get ready. That is what tonight is for."

Zola bumped her shoulder with her own, companionable and warm, and her markings flared, bright and blue, and she did not try to dim them, because Zola never hid her markings, and never had.

"Then we will get ready together," Zola said, and her voice was loud, and certain, and it settled Yara the way the river settled the village, low and steady and always there. "That is what a tracker is for. You lead, and I watch your back, and when Jabari tries to make it harder than it has to be, I will be there to say so. That is what I do."

At the fire, Amara was already packing her satchel, and when she saw Yara she waved her over, and her eyes were kind, and tired, and steady, the way they always were in the morning, when the day had not yet asked anything of her.

"Yara," Amara said, and her voice was calm, and patient, and it settled Yara the way the river settled the village. "Come and walk with me. Not to the river, today. Just around the clearing, where it is quiet. I would like the company, and I think you would like the quiet."

Yara nodded, and she felt the relief in her chest loosen a little, because an ordinary morning, on the day of the announcement, felt like a gift.

A WALK WITH AMARA

They walked in the slow, easy way Amara always walked, stopping to look at things, and to smell things, and to teach things, and Yara listened, and learned, and breathed, and for a while the trial, and the fire, and the whole village watching, all felt very far away, the way a storm feels far away when you are standing in the sun.

"You are quiet," Amara said, after a while, and her voice was gentle, and it was not a question, and it was not a scolding, and it was just Amara, noticing, the way she always noticed. "Quieter than usual. And your markings are doing that thing they do when you are thinking too hard."

Yara looked down at her arms, and her markings were bright, and blue, and restless, and she breathed, slow, and breathed them down again, until they were only a faint, blue shimmer, easy to miss, easy to mistake for light through leaves.

"I am thinking about the promise," Yara said, quietly, so that it was for Amara and not for the clearing, and not for the village. "My mother's promise. One true thing about my father, when the east trail was mine by daylight too. It is mine now. It has been mine for three days. And tonight she announces the trial, and I do not know if she will keep the promise tonight, or if she will wait, or if she has forgotten."

Amara was quiet for a long moment, and Yara watched her face, and saw, in her face, the thing she had been afraid she would see: sadness, and understanding, and something older and deeper, the way Amara's face went when she was thinking about the past, and about people who were gone.

"She has not forgotten," Amara said, at last, and her voice was soft, and certain, and it settled Yara the way the river settled the village. "Your mother does not forget a promise, Yara. Not ever. Not even the ones she wishes she had not made. She will keep it. In her own time, and in her own way, but she will keep it. That is who she is."

Yara nodded, and her throat was tight, and she felt the hope in her chest stand up a little straighter.

"And Amara," she said, and her voice was low, and her hands were pressed flat against her thighs to keep them still. "The thing you told me, by the river, after the east trail. About my father. That whatever took him, it was not because he stopped. I have been thinking about that too. Every night, for three nights. Do you think my mother's one true thing will be the same as yours? Or different?"

Amara stopped walking, and turned, and looked at Yara, and her eyes were kind, and sad, and steady, and she laid her hand, very gently, on Yara's arm, the way she laid her hand on anyone who was hurt, and afraid, and trying very hard not to show it.

"I think," Amara said, slowly, and her voice was soft, and it was for Yara and not for the clearing, "that there is more than one true thing about a person, Yara. Your father was a whole person, not one sentence. What I told you was true. What your mother tells you will be true too. And they will not be the same, because they will not be about the same part of him. That is how people are. They are too big for one true thing."

Yara felt her breath catch, and then settle, and she nodded, and her throat was too tight to speak.

"Thank you," she said, quietly, so that it was for Amara and not for the clearing. "Thank you for telling me yours. And thank you for telling me that."

They walked on, and the morning went on, ordinary and bright, and Yara thought, with a clarity that frightened her, that this was what she was fighting for: a village, and a morning, and a mentor who walked slow, and a mother who kept her promises.

At midday, Zola found her at the training ground, and Zola was not alone. She had brought her spear, and her grin, and a plan, and the plan was simple, and it was Zola all over: practice.

"Three days is not long," Zola said, and her voice was loud, and certain, and she planted her spear in the dust, and looked at Yara, and did not look away. "But it is long enough to be ready, if we use it. So we will use it. Today, we run the trails. Tomorrow, we track. And the day after, we rest, and we sharpen, and we breathe,

the way Amara taught us. That is the plan. Do you agree?”

Yara nodded, and she felt the fear in her chest stand up a little straighter, and then the pride that came with it.

“I agree,” she said, and her voice was steady, and her chin was up. “Let us run the trails.”

RUNNING THE TRAILS

They ran the trails the way hunters run them: fast, and quiet, and low, through the trees, and over the roots, and along the river path, and Yara felt her body remember what it knew, and her senses open the way they opened when she was hunting.

Zola ran ahead, and Yara ran behind, and then Yara ran ahead, and Zola ran behind, and they traded the lead the way trackers trade it, without speaking, without slowing, without thinking about it, because that was what they had always done, since they were small, and the jungle was their playground, and the trails were their home.

“Good,” Zola said, when they stopped at last, at the top of the ridge, and her voice was breathless, and proud, and a little bit surprised, all at once, and Yara recognised all three, because she felt all three herself. “You are faster than you were. And quieter. And your markings are steadier. Amara’s breathing is working. You are not the girl who came to the training ground at dawn and could not dim her markings. You are —” she stopped, and laughed, very quietly, “— you are a hunter, Yara. Whether Jabari says so or not.”

Yara felt her throat go tight, and her markings flare, bright and blue, before she could stop them, and she breathed them down again, slow and steady, and she looked at Zola, and did not look away.

“Thank you,” she said, quietly, so that it was for Zola and not for the ridge, and not for the jungle. “Thank you for saying that. And thank you for running with me. I could not do this without you. I know that. I have always known that.”

Zola bumped her shoulder with her own, companionable and warm, and her eyes were bright, and her face was serious, and she said, quietly, so that only Yara could hear, “You could. You could do it without me. But you should not have to. That is what a tracker is for. You lead, and I watch your back. That is the deal. That is what it has always been.”

They walked back to the village in the slow, easy way hunters walk when the work is done, and the sun was going down, and the fire was being lit in the temple clearing, and the whole village was gathering, and Yara felt, with every step, the evening pulling at her.

At the fire, the village was already seated, in the wide circle around the flames, and Oya was standing on the temple steps, and her face was calm, and level, and afraid, all at once, and Yara understood, without being told, that her mother was afraid too.

Jabari was seated at the edge of the circle, apart from the others, and his face was cold, and his voice, when he spoke, was cold too, and it carried across the whole clearing, and Yara felt every eye turn towards him, and then towards her, and her markings flared, bright and blue, before she could stop them.

“Three days,” Jabari said, and his voice was flat, and it cut across the clearing like a blade. “Three days ago, I called for the trial, and the queen agreed, and the village heard it. Tonight is the night. Tonight, the trial is announced. And I will set it, as is the old way, and as is my right as elder. That is the law. That is how it has always been.”

The clearing went very slightly quiet, and Yara felt her temper flare, hot and sudden, and she breathed, slow, and let the feeling be there without feeding it, and she looked at Jabari, and did not look away, and she said, very quietly, so that it was for him and not for the clearing, “Then set it, Jabari. I am listening. The whole village is listening. Set it, and I will face it.”

Jabari looked at her for a long moment, his old eyes level and wintry, and Yara made herself meet them, and not look away, and not dim her markings, and not shrink, and then, slowly, the elder nodded, once, the way he had nodded on the training ground, and on the east trail, when she had passed his test by letting a feeling be there without feeding it.

“Then hear it,” Jabari said, and he stood, slowly, and his spear was in his hand, and his voice was level, and carrying, and it settled over the village like a hand settling over a fire. “Hear the trial, Yara of Kijani. Hear it, and remember it, because I will not say it twice.”

THE ANNOUNCEMENT

Oya raised her hand, and the clearing went still, and the fire crackled, and the whole village waited, and Yara felt her heart beating hard enough that she could feel it in her teeth, and she understood, with a clarity that frightened her, that this was the moment everything had been leading to.

“The trial is mine to announce,” Oya said, and her voice was level, and carrying, and it settled over the village like a hand settling over a fire. “And Jabari will set it, as is the old way, and as is his right as elder. But the trial is mine to announce, because Yara is my daughter, and because she is the princess of this village, and because she is the heir to Kijani. So hear me, all of you. Hear me, and remember.”

She stepped down from the temple steps, and she walked to the fire, and she stood beside it, and the flames lit her face, and her markings, and her braids, and her armour, and she looked, Yara thought, like a queen, and like a mother, both at once.

“Yara,” Oya said, and her voice was steady, and it was her voice, and it was also, Yara realised, her mother’s voice, the way Oya’s voice sounded when she gave an order she wished she did not have to give. “In three days, you will face your trial. Three days to prepare, from tonight. Three days, and then the jungle will ask you what you are, and you will answer it, alone, the way a hunter answers it, and the village will hear your answer, and the village will know.”

Three days. The words hung in the clearing, and Yara felt them land in her chest, heavy and bright at once, and Oya’s face did something it almost never did in front of the village: it softened, and it was proud, and it was afraid, both at once.

“Three days,” Yara said, and her voice was steady, and her chin was up, and her hands were pressed flat against her thighs to keep them still. “I will be ready.”

“And now,” Oya said, and her voice went quieter, so that it was for the fire and not for the clearing, “hear the setting of it, from Jabari, who has set trials since before I was born, and who knows the old way better than anyone living.”

Jabari stepped forward, and his spear was in his hand, and his face was cold, and his voice was cold, and it carried across the whole clearing, and Yara felt every eye turn towards him, and her markings flared, bright and blue, before she could stop them.

“The trial is this,” Jabari said, and his voice was flat, and it cut across the clearing like a blade. “Alone, in the jungle, for a full day and a full night, from dawn to dawn. No tracker. No help. No spear from another hunter’s hand. You will track, and you will hunt, and you will bring back proof of the hunt, and you will bring yourself back, whole, and unbroken, and you will do it by the old law: never hunt the weak, never hunt for fun alone, respect your prey, and keep the secret. That is the trial. That is what makes a hunter.”

Yara nodded, and her throat was tight, and she felt the fear in her chest stand up a little straighter, and then the pride that came with it.

“Alone,” she said, quietly, so that it was for Jabari and not for the clearing. “A full day and a full night. Dawn to dawn. I understand.”

“And one more thing,” Jabari said, and his voice was level, and carrying, and it settled over the village like a hand settling over a fire. “The trial trail will be the north trail, not the east. The east is yours, and it is watched, and it is yours to keep. The north is wilder, and it is harder, and it is where the old trials were held, when I was young. That is where you will go. That is where the jungle will ask you what you are.”

Yara felt her breath catch, and then settle, and she nodded, and her throat was too tight to speak, and for a moment, standing by the fire in the firelight, she felt like she belonged, fully, in both of her worlds at once, and it did not tear her in two.

“Then it is announced,” Oya said, and her voice was level, and carrying, and it settled over the village like a hand settling over a fire. “Three days to prepare. Three days, and then Yara faces her trial, alone, on the north trail, from dawn to dawn. And the village will watch, and the village will wait, and the village will know.”

The clearing went very slightly quiet, and then, slowly, the village began to talk, and to move, and to go back to their food, and their stories, and their evening, and Yara stood by the fire, and felt the trial land in her chest, heavy and bright at once.

ONE TRUE THING

But the fire was not done with her yet. Yara knew it, because her mother was still standing beside her, and her mother’s hand was still hovering a breath from her arm, and her mother’s face had gone quiet, in the way it went quiet when she was about to say something she had been carrying for a long time.

“Stay,” Oya said, quietly, so that it was for Yara and not for the clearing, and not for the village. “Stay by the fire a little longer, Yara. The village can wait. The trial can wait. There is something I owe you, and tonight is the night for it.”

Yara nodded, and her throat was tight, and her heart was beating hard enough that she could feel it in her teeth, and she understood, with a clarity that frightened her, that the promise was about to be kept.

They sat by the fire, mother and daughter, close enough that the flames lit both their faces, and far enough from the others that the village’s talk was only a low murmur, like the river, and Oya was quiet for a long moment, and Yara watched her mother’s face, and saw fear, and love, and grief, all at once, and under them, slower and steadier, the weight of a promise kept.

“You asked me,” Oya said, at last, and her voice was low, and steady, and it settled Yara the way the river settled the village, low and steady and always there. “You asked me, on the night you led the east trail, for one true thing about your father. And I promised you one, when the east trail was yours by daylight too. It is yours now. It is yours by dark, and it is yours by daylight, and it is yours by the village’s word, and by Jabari’s word. So tonight, I will keep my promise. One true thing.”

Yara nodded, and her hands were pressed flat against her thighs to keep them still, and her markings flared, bright and blue, before she could stop them, and she breathed them down again, slow and steady, and she looked at her mother, and did not look away.

“The last thing he said to me,” Oya said, and her voice was quiet, and it shook, just a little, the way brave voices sometimes shake, “the morning he went out and never came back, was your name. He said, ’Tell Yara I will be back before dark.’ And I believed him. I still believe he meant it.”

The words hung in the firelight, and Yara felt them land in her chest, heavy and bright at once, and her throat was too tight to speak.

“He meant to come back,” Yara said, very quietly, so that it was for her mother and not for the fire, and not for the village. “That is what you are telling me. He did not leave. He meant to come back before dark.”

“I am telling you what he said,” Oya said, and her voice was level, and carrying, and it settled over Yara like a hand settling over a fire. “That is the one true thing. He said your name, and he said he would be back before dark, and he meant it. What happened after that, I do not know. I have never known. But that is true, Yara. That is one true thing, and it is yours now, and no one can take it from you.”

Yara felt her eyes sting, and her throat go tight, and she breathed, slow, and let the feeling be there without feeding it, and she said, very quietly, so that it was for her mother and not for the fire, “Thank you, Mother. Thank you for telling me. I will keep it. I will keep it the way I keep the charm. Close, and safe, and where I can feel it hum.”

Oya nodded, once, slow and certain, and her hand came down, at last, and rested on Yara’s arm, warm and steady.

“Amara told you one true thing too,” Oya said, quietly, so that it was for Yara and not for the fire. “By the river, after the east trail. She told me. She told me what she said. And she was right. Whatever took him, it

was not because he stopped. He did not stop, Yara. Those two things are true together. They do not fight each other. They hold each other up, the way two hands hold a bowl."

Yara nodded, and her throat was too tight to speak, and her eyes were stinging, and her markings were bright, and she did not try to dim them, and she thought, with a clarity that frightened her, that she had two true things now, and that they were both hers, and that they fit together, like two pieces of a charm, and that the not-knowing was a little smaller, and that the mystery was still a mystery, and that both of those things could be true at the same time.

THREE DAYS

The first day of the three was for the body. That was what Amara said, in the morning, when Yara came to her at the healing hut, and Amara's eyes were kind, and tired, and steady, the way they always were in the morning, when the day had not yet asked anything of her.

"The first day is for the body," Amara said, and her voice was calm, and patient, and it settled Yara the way the river settled the village. "Eat well. Drink well. Sleep well. Sharpen your knife. Check your cloak. Walk the north trail as far as the edge, and no further, and learn it with your feet, before you have to learn it alone. That is the first day. The second day is for the senses. And the third day is for the quiet. Do you understand me, Yara?"

Yara nodded, and she felt the relief in her chest loosen a little, because a plan, in three parts, was a gift.

"I understand," she said, and her voice was steady, and her chin was up. "First day, the body. Second day, the senses. Third day, the quiet."

She spent the first day the way Amara had told her to spend it. She ate, and she drank, and she walked the north trail as far as the edge, and no further.and she felt the jungle open around her, wilder than the east trail, and harder, and older.

Zola walked with her, as far as the edge, and no further, and when they turned back, Zola said, quietly, so that only Yara could hear, "It is a hard trail, Yara. Harder than the east. But you are a hard hunter, too. Harder than Jabari thinks. I have seen it. I have run it with you. I know."

Yara nodded, and her throat was tight, and her markings flared, bright and blue, before she could stop them, and she breathed them down again, slow and steady, and she looked at Zola, and did not look away.

"Thank you," she said, quietly, so that it was for Zola and not for the trail. "Thank you for walking it with me. And thank you for saying that. I will remember it, when I am alone on it, and it is dark, and Jabari's voice is in my head."

At the fire that evening, the village talked about the trial in low voices, and with many glances towards Yara, and Yara sat by the fire, and listened, and ate, and breathed, and felt the trial land in her chest, heavy and bright at once.

The second day was for the senses. She went to the healing hut in the morning, and Amara taught her to breathe, and to listen, and to smell, and to feel the jungle with her markings, and not just with her eyes, and Yara listened, and learned, and breathed, and for a while the trial, and the fire, and the whole village watching, all felt very far away, the way a storm feels far away when you are standing in the sun.

"Your markings are a sense too," Amara said, and her voice was calm, and patient. "They tingle when danger is near. They flare when you are afraid. They dim when you are calm. Learn to read them, Yara, the way you read a trail. They are not a weakness. They are a warning, and a gift, both at once."

Yara nodded, and she breathed, slow, and let the feeling be there without feeding it.

"I will learn," she said, quietly, so that it was for Amara and not for the hut. "I will learn to read them. And I will learn to trust them. That is what you taught me. That is what I will do."

In the afternoon, Jabari came to the training ground, and he stood at the edge, and his voice was cold, and it carried across the whole clearing, and Yara felt every eye turn towards him.

“Tomorrow is the third day,” Jabari said, and his voice was flat, and it cut across the clearing like a blade. “Tomorrow is for the quiet. And the day after, at dawn, you go north, alone. I have set the trial. The old way. The hard way. Do not ask me to make it easier, Yara. I will not.”

Yara looked at him for a long moment, and she made herself meet his eyes, and not look away, and then, slowly, she nodded, once.

“I will not ask,” she said, and her voice was level, and her hands were still at her sides. “I do not want it easier, Jabari. I want it true. That is all I have ever wanted. Make it true, and I will face it.”

Jabari looked at her for a long moment, and his face softened, just a little, at the edges, and then, slowly, he nodded, once, slow and certain.

“Then it is true,” he said. “It is as true as I know how to make it. And that, Yara, is the best I can give you.”

THE THIRD DAY

The third day was for the quiet. That was what Amara had said, and that was what Yara did. She woke before the sun, and she lay still in her shelter, and she listened to the village wake up around her, and she thought about the two true things she carried, and about the charm at her belt, and about the north trail, waiting in the dark, and she felt, with a clarity that frightened her, that the quiet was not empty, and that it was full, the way a river is full, even when it is still.

She spent the morning with Amara, in the healing hut, and they did not talk about the trial, or the north trail, or Jabari, and they talked, instead, about herbs, and about the river, and about the new family’s old woman, whose hands were better, and about the small boy, who had caught the chicken at last, and who was very proud of himself, and Yara laughed, quietly, and then she felt the quiet settle over her, the way the river settled the village, low and steady and always there.

In the afternoon, she went to the river, alone, and she sat on the bank, where she and Amara had found Elena, three days ago, and she thought about the human woman, and about the promise, and about the name, Dane Mercer, and about the snares, and about the way the two worlds she lived between pulled at her, one in each hand.

She did not go looking for Elena. Oya had forbidden it, and Yara understood why, and she kept the order, and she sat on the bank, and she listened to the river, and she thought about the human who kept to her own path now, the way Yara kept to hers, and she thought that was enough, for now.

She took the bone charm from her belt, and held it in her hand, and looked at it in the river light, and felt it hum, once, low and warm, the way it had hummed on the night of the second chapter, and on the night of the fifth, and on the night of the sixth, and on the morning of the seventh, and she thought about what her mother had told her, by the fire, and about what Amara had told her, by the river.

“He said your name,” she whispered, very quietly, so that it was for the river and not for the jungle, and not for the village. “He said, ’Tell Yara I will be back before dark.’ And he meant it. And whatever took him, it was not because he stopped. Those two things are true together. And I will carry them both, the way I carry the charm. Close, and safe, and where I can feel them hum.”

She put the charm back in its place, and she sat by the river a little longer, and she breathed, slow, and she let the quiet be there without feeding it, and she felt her markings dim, until they were only a faint, blue shimmer, and she thought, with a clarity that frightened her, that she was ready, or as ready as she could be.

At the fire that evening, the last evening before the trial, Oya came and sat beside her, and her face was calm, and level, and afraid, all at once, and Yara understood, without being told, that her mother was afraid too.

“Tomorrow, at dawn,” Oya said, quietly, so that it was for Yara and not for the fire, and not for the village. “Tomorrow, at dawn, you go north, alone, and the jungle asks you what you are. And I will be here, at the fire, waiting, and the village will be here, waiting, and we will all be waiting, together, for you to come home.”

Yara nodded, and her throat was tight, and her eyes were stinging, and she breathed, slow and steady, and she looked at her mother, and did not look away.

“I will come home,” she said, and her voice was steady, and her chin was up. “I will come home, Mother. I promise you that. That is a promise with a time on it, the way yours was. Tomorrow, at dawn, I go north. And the day after, at dawn, I come home.”

Oya nodded, once, slow and certain, and her hand came down, at last, and rested on Yara’s arm, warm and steady, and Yara felt the weight of it, and the warmth of it, and she understood, with a clarity that frightened her, that her mother had just made a promise too, and that the promise was in the hand, and in the waiting, and in the fire, all at once.

THE EVE OF THE TRIAL

That night, Yara sat in her shelter, alone, with the sketch in her hand, and looked at it in the dark, and thought about everything that had happened, and everything that was going to happen, and she felt, with a clarity that frightened her, that her life had changed, in three days, by a fire.

She had been given a trial, and she had been given three days to prepare for it, and she had been given one true thing about her father, from her mother’s own mouth, and she had been given a second true thing, from Amara, and the not-knowing was a little smaller, and the mystery was still a mystery, and both of those things could be true at the same time.

And now there was a trial, in the morning, and Jabari had set it, and it would be hard, because Jabari wanted it to be hard, and Yara would have to face it, alone, in the jungle, on the north trail, from dawn to dawn, and prove herself, not as a human, and not as a hunter, but as Yara, both at once.

In her shelter, she took the bone charm from her belt, and held it in her hand, and looked at it in the dark, and felt it hum, once, low and warm, the way it had hummed on the night of the second chapter, and on the night of the fifth, and on the night of the sixth, and on the morning of the seventh, and she thought about what her mother had promised her: one true thing, when the east trail was hers by daylight too.

It was hers now, she thought, and her markings flared, bright and blue, and she breathed them down again, slow and steady. It was hers by dark, and it was hers by daylight, and it was hers by the village’s word, and it was hers by Jabari’s word, and now there was a trial, and a north trail, and two true things about her father, and all of it was hers to carry, and she would carry it, because that was what being Yara was, even if she had never wanted the crown.

She put the sketch down, carefully, beside her bowl, where she could see it in the morning, and she put the charm back in its place, and she lay down, and she slept, and she dreamed, not of snares, and not of the man in the trees, but of a fire, and a mother sitting beside it, patient and kind and brave, waiting for a question to come back and be read, and of a trial, waiting in the jungle, one dawn away, and of a father, somewhere, waiting too, for his daughter to find him.

Three days. That was the truest thing she knew, truer than her fear, truer than her pride. In three days, she had been given a trial, and a promise kept, and two true things, and in the morning, she would face the trial, and the village would know, and she would know, and her mother would know, what she was.

She slept, and the village slept, and the trails were watched, and the east trail was hers, and the river was bright, and the north trail was waiting, and the trial was coming.

End of Chapter 7

Yara's trial was announced at the fire — alone, on the north trail, from dawn to dawn — and Oya kept her promise, telling Yara one true thing about her father. Three days of preparation are done. In the morning, Yara goes north.

Next: Chapter 8 — Yara faces her trial alone on the north trail, from dawn to dawn, while the village waits at the fire.

Book plan: 20 chapters, about 250 pages — Act 1 is Chapters 1–5, Act 2 is Chapters 6–14, Act 3 is Chapters 15–20. Chapters 1–7 are now written. Series: Yara of Kijani. Book 1: Daughter of Two Worlds.

Daughter of Two Worlds was written by BiomassFlood, with AI assistance from Luna for drafting and editing. All characters, worldbuilding, and story decisions are the author's own original work.